



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

'Fans should be given the power of choosing their own experience'

In the panel titled 'Stadiums Without Walls – Building the Next Fan Universe', (from left to right) Siddharth Sharma (Head, Viewership and Monetisation Initiative – Sports, JioStar), Veer Damaraju (EVP, Technology, DAZN India), Aneesh Madani (former Head of Partnerships & Innovation, International Olympic Committee), and Nikhil Bansal (Head – Gaming & eServices, Google India) joined L.V. Navaneeth (CEO, *The Hindu Group*) to discuss how sporting organisations are engaging fans worldwide.

The session explored how new-age technologies, data analytics, and collaborations are being harnessed to overcome the unique challenges of enhancing fan engagement.

According to Siddharth, fans should be given the power to choose their own experience. "The acceleration of technology has made sports more inclusive, interactive, immersive, and intuitive — the four Is that we as a network live by. We

are fortunate to be at the forefront of this transformation, even acting as a catalyst."

Damaraju added that fans don't just want to be spectators.

"We are moving more towards the control shifting from editorial teams to the fans. Fans are now able to dictate what kind of video they want. It means video on demand is shifting to video on prompt. This is what the industry is moving towards."

Madani weighed in on innovation aiding accessibility, saying, "One of my favourite sports experiences was watching IPL on Hotstar, being able to seamlessly switch languages and really experience the sport differently. And one of the questions I think about, especially for cricket, is what the language of engagement is

going to be like for cricket in the future? How is that enabled with AI technology?

"When cricket goes to the Olympics in 2028, we will get broadcast of the game in countries which have not necessarily had that sport before. So, what does cricket sound like in Mandarin? What does it sound like in French? Could be interesting. And hopefully some of that is inspired, and hopefully even from India to the world."

When asked how sporting federations, leagues, and teams can leverage the digital ecosystem to create interactive and personalised fan experiences, Nikhil said the sports economy itself is evolving. "When we talk about fan experiences, I think the fans and consumers have evolved, sports have become more diverse, and of course, the digital economy and even commercialisation of sports have come a really long way. You are talking about a \$50 billion number; we took out a report as Google, a slightly larger number, we had a \$130 billion number for 2030."

